STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 16 · Before the Fall

Transcript · Wes Hart

Good. You found a chair. Come on and settle. Uh, I wrote three openings on a card and left the card by the sink. My wife found it. She said, pick one. You're not running for office. She was right. So this is the one. If you still need a name, I'm Wes. Glad you're in the room. Uh, some of you carried the day in on your face. Set it in the chair beside you. It can sit there and hear this too. Last time we talked about what a man measures his life by. What he treats as fixed when it moves under him. Uh, some of you said yours plain. Some of you, uh, kept the name to yourself. We're not— we're not opening that up again. You can name what you've been steering by and still not know what you were made for. That second thing is today. Before the bend. Before the account you give of the bend. What God did when He made a man. Then two ways a man can walk once that ground is actually his. You don't get a third. Now listen to me. I know where a room full of men wants to start. At the wreck. At the thing that failed. Uh, I start there too. Ask me what went wrong and I can talk until the chairs get hard. Ask me what it was for before it went wrong, and I get, you know, very interested in the ceiling. Stay on the first page with me. Design was first. The fork comes after. Uh, skip the design, and a bent life just feels like weather you endure. Weather doesn't ask you to turn. Here's what I want in your ear. You were made on purpose. The work was handed to you before the trouble. And you are already standing in one man's way.

These four marks are the sentence we keep coming back to. I have not improved them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You've heard them in this room. Uh, I'm not gonna build all four from the ground up. Today they stop being a list of qualities you grade yourself against. It is— it is a portrait. A Man's face in the worst hour He had. We'll stand in front of that hour. Not yet. If I hand you the face first, you'll hear pressure where I meant a gift. Uh, hear the four this way, just for a minute. Passivity, today, is a man in the room who says nothing while a true word gets bent. Responsibility is a sentence that can land on you and stop, with no second name tied on the end. Courage is getting up and walking toward the hard thing while you still want a different ending. And God's pay is not the relief you can pocket before supper. It is His pay. A yes from Him that outlasts the room you're standing in. I mean, the near yes pays faster. It just doesn't keep. Here's the claim under the marks. You were made to work a real thing and to keep it. The assignment showed up before the curse. Then one man went quiet, and another Man did not. Every time you live one of these marks, you are wearing His face. Not performing it. Wearing it. Uh, that sounds large until you see the hour it came from. It was not a stage. It was a dark place and a choice. Design first. Then the fork. One hit. You need both, or the portrait turns into a mood and the design turns into a poster.

Scripture does not start you as a problem. The problem comes in. It is not the first word. Genesis one, verse twenty-seven. God created mankind in his own image. In the image of God. Male and female. Uh, before a success you can point at. Before a failure you can't stop rehearsing. You were made to resemble Him. Uh, nobody sold you that. You didn't qualify for it. It was given. Uh, manhood is not a step above your wife, or above your daughter, or above any woman in your life. It is one way of carrying the same image. And the way was His idea. Uh, then, Genesis two. He formed a man and came close enough to breathe into him. Hands, then a face near. You were wanted before you were useful. I have— I have had that backwards for a long stretch of my life. Useful first. Wanted if the useful held. Uh, that is not the order on the page. How many of you, if I ask what you were made for, start telling me what went wrong? Hands. I'm not collecting them. Yeah. That's most of us. We can narrate the crack and go thin on the purpose. Stay with me. The crack matters. It is just not page one. So hear it plain. You are an image-bearer on purpose. Wanted, up close, before you produced a thing. Uh, the failure is in the story. It is not the opening line. If you only know yourself as the man who broke something, you will try to repair a life you have never actually looked at. Formed. Breathed on. Made in His image before the day asked you for a result. If the rest of today gets noisy, don't lose that. The bend is real. The bend is not the introduction.

Now the line I want you to keep. Genesis two, verse fifteen. The Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and take care of it. Took. Then put. Uh, he didn't toss a man at the horizon and wish him luck. He took him. He set him down. The assignment had a place. Work it. Take care of it. Two verbs, and nothing is broken yet. Uh, the curse is not on the page. The work already is. Uh, if your only picture of work is punishment, you started the story too late. The curse made good work ache. It did not invent the work. And take care of it means keep it. Uh, watch over it. The same man who works the place is the man who guards what was put in his hands. Not two jobs. One man. The job— the job came before the curse. You were made to work a real thing and to keep a real thing. Uh, let me tell on myself. I have cleared a list and then stood in a room with nothing left on it, and I got nervous. So I reordered a drawer that was already fine. I looked busy. I was unused, and I didn't like the feeling, so I manufactured a task. The design was still talking. A man with nothing real to tend doesn't feel free. He feels misplaced. Uh, and I have used a real task to avoid a real person. Sat in the driveway. Engine off. One more message, then one more after that. Porch light already on. Somebody inside was waiting on my actual face. I called it finishing the day. It was postponing the people the day was for. Work it and keep it. I worked a screen. I did not keep what was mine to keep.

Uh, blessing came before the assignment. The first words He spoke over them were a blessing. Then the work. Who you are, then what you do. Uh, if you only feel like a man when the output is up, you flipped that order. He also put the man somewhere. Not a vague someday. A lot of us treat where we are as a pause, and the place we have goes unkept. Uh, he was given a word he did not write. Most of it was a yes. One thing was a no. You live inside that word. You don't get

to redraw it. Uh, stay inside it when it costs. He was also given words of his own. Uh, what you call a person sticks. A boy leans toward the sentence you use on him over and over. So does a wife. Uh, I can tell you what I got done. Ask me the last true thing I said to my boy that was not an instruction, and I have to stand there and hunt. My words, bent toward managing. And God looked at a man who had Him, and a real assignment, and no sin on the record yet, and He said it was not good for that man to be alone. Genesis two, verse eighteen. Needing people is not the wreck. It was written in before the wreck. Brothers. A man out ahead of you. A church that knows your name. If you're single, you are inside that sentence. You are not on hold until a bride appears. They were fully known, and not afraid of being known. And God rested, and He called the stop holy. He was not worn out. I have— I have skipped that stop and called the rush faithfulness. My house did not feel kept. Name the piece most bent in you. One. The shape is not the whole hit.

Let me walk the room before we go to the fork. Uh, if you're young, and you're waiting to feel like a man before you take a man's way, hear this. Waiting is already a way. Delayed is still a way. It is the quiet way with a future tense on it. Uh, if you're single, don't go hunting for a marriage talk in this. A wedding does not finish a man. Nearly everything God gave him, He gave before a bride was standing there. Jesus lived the fullest life a man has lived, and there was no wife in that life. You can work what's yours and keep what's yours now. If you're married, she already knows which man came home. Uh, you don't have to announce it from the doorway. The way you came in said it. I told my wife I was almost done with a thing that could've waited. She didn't give a speech. She said the plates were still cold. She has a better read on which man arrived than I do. If you're hurt, I am not stepping over you. The wound is real. It is not the first page. And it is not a third man. There is not a way called wounded sitting between the other two. You can be hurt and still walk the first man's way. The hurt explains weight. It does not open a new road. Uh, if you're older, look through Genesis two, verse fifteen, for a line that sends you to the side for good. It isn't there. The place you're given can change. The making does not retire. And if the work is going well, good. Receive it. Uh, the blessing came before the output. Gift first. Then the hands. Uh, don't let a strong set of hands talk you out of the rest of the design.

Now the fork. Same ground. Two men. You are in one. The first man had the word. He had the place. He had a good work in his hands. Uh, then the lie came, and it didn't come straight at him. It bent the word where someone near him could hear it, and it hinted that God was holding out. Genesis three, verse six. She gave some to her husband, who was with her, and he ate. He was with her. Present. Quiet. Passivity, with his feet still planted. The thing he was set there to keep walked right up, and he watched, and then he took it in. Uh, the first break was the silence while a true word got twisted. Uh, then God came, and the man hid. Afraid, so he got out of sight. Uh, asked what he had done, he pointed. The woman. And the God who gave her. His own hands left out of the sentence. Under that, he grabbed what he could have now. God's pay,

traded for the thing in reach. Quiet, pointing, hidden, grabbing. That groove is easy to find, right? I have— I have lived in it and called it a personality. A family table. Somebody took a hard line of Scripture and sanded it down until it excused him. I passed the bread. I said nothing. I called it not making a scene. It was the first man's way with better manners. Uh, another day I got sharp with my boy over shoes in the doorway. First sentence out of me was how long the day had been. The day didn't raise its voice. I did. Uh, and I have moved a hard talk into a note I named Later. Later felt organized. Later was a place to hide. You know that groove. Name it, so you stop calling it wisdom.

Let me tell you about a man I know. Uh, I'll call him Nolan. Steady man. Drives a route. People trust him with a key and a time. Uh, his boy got in a fight at school. Not the end of the world. Enough that the school wanted the dad in the office before the story hardened. Nolan had stops left. Uh, he told them he'd come when the truck was empty, because showing up with work unfinished felt sloppy. So he— so he finished the stops. By the time he walked into that office, the boy had already talked. A messy account, half defense and half shame. Nolan sat down. The boy looked at the floor and said, I told it wrong. I kept watching the door. That sentence sat on Nolan the whole drive after. Not the fight. The door. He had been the man who would show up when the truck allowed it. He called that keeping his word. It was the first way, wearing a timetable. I mean, the route was real. The boy was more real, and Nolan ranked them backwards. Some time later a smaller call came. Uh, a teacher wanted a few minutes before the day got loud. Nolan left the truck at the curb. Hazards on. He went in before he felt noble. Sat in a chair built for a student. He said, I'm here. We'll tell it straight. I'll stay where he can see me. He told me later it was the first time the second Man made any sense in his actual life. A tired man who got up, left the easy finish, and walked toward the person given to him. Rise. Let us go. Let these men go. Nolan did not become Jesus. He stopped taking the first man's way and calling it a finished route.

Set the two men next to each other. Uh, the first went quiet while the word was bent. The second spoke. The first pointed. The second said, take me, and let them go. The first hid when God came near. The second got down before the Father and then got up. The first grabbed what he could hold. The second trusted a reward on the far side of the cost. This is the portrait. Jesus, in the worst hour of His life. Matthew twenty-six, verse thirty-nine. Uh, he asked if the cup could pass. He did— he did not want it. Then He said, not as I will, but as you will. He took a cup He did not fill. Then He said, rise. Let us go. Uh, he heard what was coming and He walked at it. John eighteen, verse four. He went out and asked who they wanted. Nobody had to hunt for Him. Afraid enough to tell the Father the truth, and still on His feet, toward the worst of it. That is courage. And while they closed in, He put Himself in front of the men with Him. John eighteen, verse eight. If you're looking for me, then let these men go. Caught, He aimed the finger at Himself. Me. Not them. Uh, Hebrews twelve, verse two. For the joy set before Him, He endured. John nineteen. It is finished. Uh, he lived for the Father's reward, and He spoke the

work done before He died. So hear the four marks as His mouth. Refusing to wait sounds like, rise, let us go. Picking up the weight sounds like, not as I will, and let these men go. Going first is the walking out while you still want another way. Working for God's pay is the joy set in front of Him, past the cost. Every time you live one, you are wearing His face.

First Corinthians fifteen, verse twenty-two. As in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive. And verse forty-five. The first man Adam became a living being. The last Adam, a life-giving spirit. Last. Not a man you become by trying harder. Birth put you in the first man. Uh, his way feels like sense. Quiet feels smart. Pointing feels like justice. Hiding feels like safety. Grabbing the near thing feels like you finally got yours. Romans five, verse nineteen. Through one man's disobedience, the many were made sinners. Through one man's obedience, the many will be made righteous. You are— you are in one of them. Trying harder is not the door. The door is a move into the second Man, so His obedience stands as your record. Galatians two, verse twenty. I no longer live, but Christ lives in me. The Spirit that got Him up lives in a man who is in Him. If you have never asked Him to move you, you can ask Him today. Tell Him the first man's way is the only one you have known. Tell Him you want the second Man. His life, covering yours. Uh, if you have asked, don't turn the marks into a ladder. They are not how you earn Him. They are His life showing on a man who is already His. Uh, I knew a man, I'll call him Cliff. A wrong number in a meeting was about to land on a younger guy. Cliff said, that figure was mine. His hands shook under the table. The easy sentence was the one that points. He didn't take it. He told me he felt sick, not holy. The younger man didn't carry Cliff's miss. Let these men go, in a room with a shaking hand.

So bring it down to the ground you actually stand on. A garden, the way I mean it today, is the place where a true thing is on the line and you are the man in the room. A conversation you've been feeding with Later. The size is not the weight. Uh, your garden will look ordinary and still decide which man you practiced. Uh, here is what you do with that. Not a stack of resolutions. A sentence, said out loud, before the day picks one for you. Three of His. Rise, let us go. That one is for the place you would rather stay seated. Not as I will. Uh, that one is for the cup you didn't ask for and still have in your hands. Let these men go. That one is for the people who will carry your trouble if you point. You don't need all three before breakfast. You need the one that fits the garden you're actually entering. I have given a whole speech to a steering wheel about the true thing I was gonna say. Then I walked through the door and we talked about the weather. Say it— say it where your mouth can learn it. Uh, on an ordinary morning, read Genesis one and two out loud, start to finish. Then write one line about what it says a man is for. And each morning after, name the garden you're most likely to face and say the sentence before you walk into it. Uh, how many of you can already feel that place, the one waiting when you leave this chair? Hands. Be honest. Yeah. Don't lose it on the way to the table. If you've never trusted Christ to move you out of Adam, say it plain and let a brother walk you through it. If you have,

tell him one garden where you walked the second Man's way, even if it was small and your hands shook.

Let me land it. You were made on purpose. The job came before the curse. You were made to work it and keep it. Uh, then two men. Two ways. The first went quiet, pointed, hid, and grabbed. The second spoke, took the cup, sought the Father, and trusted the reward past the cost. You don't get a third. Uh, the wound is real. It is not a third man. Trying harder is not the door. Christ is. The four marks are not a list of qualities. They are the portrait of Jesus in the worst hour of His life. Every time you live one, you are wearing His face. What I hope you walk out with is one bent piece, named, one garden, named, and a clear knowing of which man you are in. Your workbook is where it gets particular. Uh, in a minute you'll sit at the tables and work this part together. Get the questions in your ear. Which piece of the blueprint is most bent in you? Say it in a full sentence. What was the last garden you stood in, and which man's way did you take? And which sentence will you say tomorrow morning? Rise, let us go. Or, not as I will. Or, let these men go. Uh, tell a brother the piece you named, and what walking back toward it would actually look like. Ask him which piece he sees bent in you. Tell him which man you are in, in the deepest sense. If you have never trusted Christ to move you, say that, and let him walk with you. Uh, if you have, tell him one garden you walked the second Man's way through. Carry this, and write it where you'll see it. You were made to work it and keep it. The job came before the curse. Wear His face into the ordinary place that is yours to keep.